STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



STRATEGY

WHY STRATEGY GETS LOST IN THE MIDDLE

What happens between the plan and the work: managers who cannot name the priorities, units that cannot rely on each other, and five myths about execution.

28% of the executives and middle managers responsible for executing strategy could list three of their company's strategic priorities.

MIT SMR, 2018

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97% said they understood the strategy

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THE NUMBERS

Managers rely on their boss, not on the other units

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The priority card

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In this issue

A strategy can be clear at the top and still never reach the work. Where it gets lost is the subject here: the middle, between the people who decide it and the people who carry it out.

In studies published since 2015, Donald Sull and colleagues have surveyed thousands of managers. Their findings point the same way. Many managers cannot name the priorities of their own company. Most can rely on their boss and their team, but far fewer on the other units they depend on. And the researchers warn that alignment from the top is not the same as coordination across the organisation.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

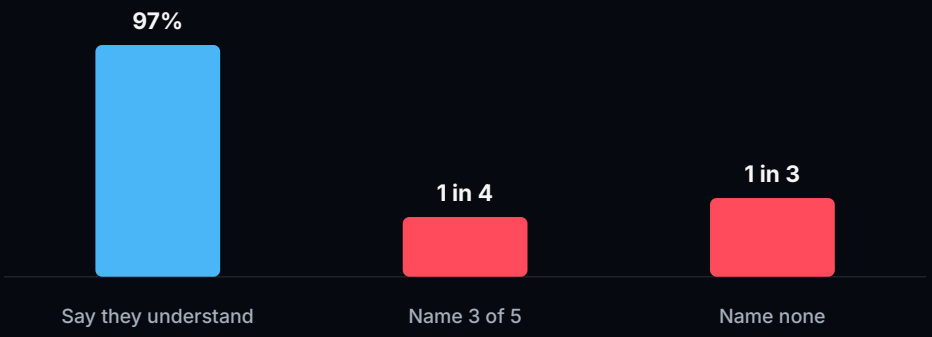
Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Everyone says they understand

In a large technology company, which the researchers call Generex, almost all senior leaders said they understood the priorities. Then the same leaders were asked to name them.

GENEREX: SAYING AND KNOWING



Shares of the same senior leaders in one large technology company, which the researchers call Generex (Sull & Yoder, 2018). A single company.

All three bars count the same leaders: what they said, then what they could list. The same researchers then looked at 124 organisations: only 28% of the executives and middle managers responsible for execution could list three of their company's strategic priorities.

OUR READING

Most strategies get lost on the way, before anyone has had the chance to reject them: they never reach, clearly, the people who make the daily decisions.

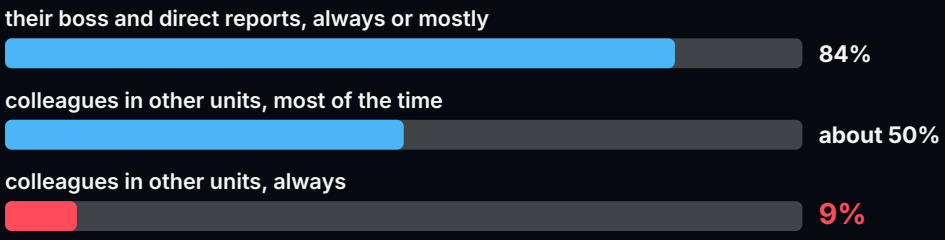
Source: Charles Sull, Donald Sull & James Yoder, MIT Sloan Management Review, 2018

THE NUMBERS

Up and down it works, sideways it does not

In the survey of nearly 8,000 managers in more than 250 companies, the chain of command held. The links between units did not.

MANAGERS WHO CAN RELY ON…



Share of nearly 8,000 managers in more than 250 companies who answered the survey (Sull, Homkes & Sull, 2015). Their own view of their colleagues.

1 in 3
of about 11,000 managers in 400+ organisations named the top three priorities correctly (LBS, 2015)

8%
of leaders were rated very effective at both strategy and execution (about 700 executives, 2013)

124
organisations in the 2018 study of priorities

OUR READING

Most work that matters crosses a unit boundary: the warehouse and transport, reception and housekeeping. Where reliance stops at the boundary, the strategy stops there too.

Sources: Donald Sull, Rebecca Homkes & Charles Sull, Harvard Business Review, 2015; London Business School (Rebecca Homkes & Donald Sull), 2015; Paul Leinwand, Cesare Mainardi & Art Kleiner, Harvard Business Review, 2015; Charles Sull, Donald Sull & James Yoder, MIT Sloan Management Review, 2018

THE MODEL

Five myths about execution

Sull, Homkes and Sull named five beliefs that make execution look simpler than it is. The column on the right is our summary of what they propose instead.

01	**Execution is alignment**	The harder part is coordination across units; alignment from top to bottom is the easier half.
02	**Execution is sticking to the plan**	The plan has to adapt when reality changes, without losing its direction.
03	**Communication is understanding**	A message that was sent is not yet a message that was understood.
04	**A performance culture drives execution**	It also needs to reward agility, teamwork and ambition.
05	**Execution is driven from the top**	It depends on distributed leaders: middle managers and experts close to the work.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A HOTEL
>
> Reception and housekeeping both have clear goals that fit the plan. When a group arrives early, nobody has agreed which rooms are made ready first. The alignment is there; the coordination is missing.

OUR READING

Each myth places the problem at the top or in the plan. The research finds it where the units meet.

Source: Donald Sull, Rebecca Homkes & Charles Sull, Harvard Business Review, 2015

More in the essay — Mistakes get lost between departments

DEVELOPING THE ROLE

The middle manager as the joint

If execution depends on distributed leaders, the middle manager does far more than carry messages between the top and the floor. In that role the strategy turns into decisions.

1. **Translate**
   Turn each priority into what it means for your team this month, in their words.
2. **Choose what not to do**
   A priority without something set aside is only one more task.
3. **Agree with the other units**
   Name the unit you depend on most and agree what each side delivers, and by when.
4. **Check understanding**
   Ask the team to say the priorities back, instead of asking whether they are clear.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A STORE
>
> The company wants more returning customers. For the store this month, that means no advertised item is missing from the shelf. The new window display waits. The central warehouse warns a day ahead about shortages, and on Friday each salesperson says the priority in their own words.

OUR READING

“Is that clear?” almost always gets a yes. “Tell me what we are doing first this week” shows whether it is.

The four steps are a practice proposed by the editors.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Has the strategy arrived?

Rather than asking managers whether the strategy was clear, the researchers had them write the priorities down. You can do the same in your team.

1. **Ask in writing**
   Each person writes down, without notes, the three priorities of the team or the company.

2. **Count the matches**
   How many people name the same three? How many name at least one?

3. **Ask about the other units**
   For each unit you depend on: can we rely on them always, most of the time, sometimes, rarely?

4. **Repeat after a quarter**
   The figure to watch is the share of people who name the same three.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, EIGHT MANAGERS
>
> Three name the company's three priorities, four name only one of them, one names none. Three out of eight is fewer than half, so the next meeting opens with the three priorities written on the board. (Invented numbers.)

OUR READING

If fewer than half name the same three priorities, leave new goals for later. The next meeting belongs to the ones you already have.

A practice proposed by the editors, after the method of the 2018 study.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The priority card

One page for one quarter. Fill it in with your team, then compare it with the card of the unit you depend on most.

01 Our three priorities in the team's words

02 What we will not do so that the three can happen

03 The unit we depend on most and what we need from it

04 What we deliver to them and by when

05 How we check understanding who asks, when, and how

06 Review date, and the share who named the same three

An editors' proposal for practice. Keep confidential plans and figures off the card.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

No One Knows Your Strategy — Not Even Your Top Leaders
Charles Sull, Donald Sull & James Yoder, MIT Sloan Management Review, 2018
https://sloanreview.mit.edu/?p=55347

Why Strategy Execution Unravels—and What to Do About It
Donald Sull, Rebecca Homkes & Charles Sull, Harvard Business Review, 2015
https://hbr.org/2015/03/why-strategy-execution-unravels-and-what-to-do-about-it

Two thirds of senior managers can't name their firm's top priorities
London Business School (Rebecca Homkes & Donald Sull), 2015
https://www.london.edu/news/two-thirds-of-senior-managers-cant-name-their-firms-top-priorities

Only 8% of Leaders Are Good at Both Strategy and Execution
Paul Leinwand, Cesare Mainardi & Art Kleiner, Harvard Business Review, 2015
https://hbr.org/2015/12/only-8-of-leaders-are-good-at-both-strategy-and-execution

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked "via". A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked "Our reading".



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html